DATA ENTRY AND FORMULAS

It is important to understand the basics of Excel before learning how to input data and formulas.

DATA TYPE

Data in Excel refers to the specific information you want to work with or analyse. This information can be a number, text, date, and other values. You can input data manually into individual cells, import it from external sources like text files or databases, or generate it using Excel's integrated features.

As has been mentioned before, Excel can handle different types of data:

- **Text:** this is the default data type in Excel. It includes all alphanumeric characters, symbols, and punctuation marks not used for mathematical operations. Text data can have a maximum length of 32,767 characters.
- **Numbers:** the software supports both whole numbers and decimal numbers. These numbers can be used for mathematical operations such as addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division.
- **Dates and times:** in Excel, dates and times are considered as a distinct type of information. Dates are represented by a sequence number where January 1, 1900, is assigned number 1, and each subsequent day is assigned the next consecutive number. Hours, on the other hand, are represented as fractions of a day: 0 represents midnight and 1 represents the end of the day.
- **Boolean:** Boolean data only has two values: TRUE and FALSE. This type of data is often used in conditional statements and logical tests.
- **Error:** Error values appear when a formula or function cannot produce a valid result. In these cases, Excel will show different types of errors, the most common being #DIV/0! (division by zero) and #N/A (value not available).
- **Arrays:** these values represent arrays, a set of grouped values.